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Malvasia – the first generic wine brand?



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TUESDAY 14 APRIL 2026 • 3 MIN READ

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What links the many vine varieties and wines named Malvasia, found all around the Mediterranean and beyond? Caroline Gilby MW delves into history and genetics to find answers.

It's often claimed that Malvasia is a grapevine family but a little research on the [VIVC database](#) reveals that at least 290 grape varieties have been linked to the name Malvasia or its close variants (including Malvazija, Malvagia, Malvoisie and Malmsey). The truth is that there are no dark family secrets in these days of grapevine genetics, which reveal that most Malvasias are unrelated to each other and the link is actually through a shared history of the wine trade around the Mediterranean by Venetian and other merchant traders.

Today, Malvasia continues to pop up in new locations, with plantings in places such as the US, Brazil, Argentina and Australia, adding to the intrigue – and the confusion. So let's start at the beginning, in Greece.

Monemvasia – the start of the story

Last year, a conference hosted by the [Malvasia Myth network](#) took me to the little isthmus of Monemvasia in the south-east Peloponnese, a beautifully preserved Byzantine town of twisting, cobbled, narrow alleyways, and the ruins of a fortified upper town perched on top of steep cliffs. This town, and nearby port, founded in the 6th century, seems to be the beginning of the Malvasia story. In the Middle Ages, it became an important trading post, under the rule of the Franks then Venetians who called the place Malvasia.





Monemvasia from above

They also named the sweet, rich wine made from sun-dried grapes from this area Malvasia and exported it around their trade empire as it was stable enough to survive long sea journeys. Written history goes back to 1214, when Malvasia was already a prestigious wine – recorded as being served ‘in abundance’ at a church delegation in Constantinople. In 1278, a Venetian document refers to the piracy of a ship with a load of Malvasia wine. In 1301, the Chrysobulus of Andronikos II Palaiologos refers to vineyards in the region of Monemvasia.

By the 14th century records indicate that the wine from this region was called Malvasia in the markets of Venice, and even wine shops were named Malvasie. A recipe for fighting plague kept in archives in Venice from around 1347 to 1352 suggested drinking good Malvasia. Di Manzano’s *Annali in Friuli-Venezia Giulia* written from 1388 to 1420 mentioned Malvasia 26 times, almost always as a gift to the powerful, noting that it was three times more expensive than local Terano wine.

More historical tales about Malvasia support its popularity and widespread trade. Leonardo da Vinci had a small vineyard of 16 rows of vines in Milan granted to him by Duke Ludovico Maria ‘Il Moro’ Sforza in 1498, as a reward for painting *The Last Supper*. Genetic analysis of traces of vine roots suggests that the vines were Malvasia

di Candia Aromatica – the vineyard has been replanted with Malvasia and makes wine again today. And later, in Shakespeare's *Richard III* written in 1592, the Duke of Clarence was drowned in a butt of Malmsey wine (the name for the sweetest Malvasia wine from Madeira).

The spread of Malvasia

Originally the name Malvasia was linked to origin, and it gained a reputation as a luxury product. As trade grew, the region couldn't keep up with demand. This was not helped by the Ottoman capture of Monemvasia-Malvasia in 1540, which destroyed wine production in the area. Demand was increasingly met by traders 'franchising' the name to other places in Greece, especially Paros and Crete – Candia at that time, in turn lost to the Ottomans in 1669.

At the peak of trade, quantities were so large that Muscats and other indigenous grape varieties were being used, sometimes sun-dried, and sometimes inferior wines from boiled must, and by the end of the 16th century only a handful of pure Malvasias from the original grape were still produced.

By this time, the name had become a description of style rather than of geographical origin – in effect the first generic wine brand (something that's happened many times with names like champagne, sherry, port and burgundy until the EU became protective). It seems that grapevines for Malvasia spread around the Mediterranean, especially in areas under the political influence of Venice. Possibly Greek varieties were originally introduced to establish vineyards, but, over time, domestic cultivars took over, probably better suited to local growing conditions. In time, if the wines were especially admired, the name Malvasia often became linked to a locality (eg Malvasia Istriana, Malvasia di Lipari or Malvasia Dubrovačka).

Vines growing beneath the hilltop village of Motovun in Istria, a fine source of Croatian Malvasia Istriana (aka Malvazija Istarska)

Monemvasia's modern revival

Yorgos and Elli Tsimbidi, owners of Monemvasia winery, had a dream to revive the original Malvasia story in its birthplace, which was also their hometown, after a gap of five centuries. They enlisted the help of Dr Stavroula Kourakou-Dragona and the Universities of Athens and Thessaloniki and spent several years researching local grapes before their first vineyards were planted in 2005, around 10 km (c 6 miles) from the sea. The Tsimbidis wanted to make something more than simple fresh wines and developed two ways of sun-drying: on nets on the ground and wire racks, before ageing the wine for at least two years in used oak. Yorgos also fought for the creation of a PDO for this Vin Liastos (sun-dried wine), which he got in time for the first vintage in 2010. It's a blend of 60% of the still-rare Monemvasia-Malvasia grape variety with Kydonitsa and Asproudi, which bring acidity to balance the natural luscious sweetness. A stunning taste of bottled history (available in the UK via [Hallgarten](#)).

Malvasia to the fore

Today most Malvasias are dry wines, and no one quite knows when or why this change happened. It was probably linked (as with the decline in most sweet wines) to sugar becoming readily available, and better understanding of how to keep dry wines stable. Many Malvasias are not highly regarded for their quality and disappear into anonymous blends or are hidden behind PDO names (just a few examples include Malvasia del Chianti in red Chianti, or Frascati, which must be 70% Malvasia di Candia and/or Malvasia del Lazio).

Perhaps the most important Malvasia to take pride of place on wine labels is Malvasia Istriana, or Malvazija Istarska as it is more commonly known in Croatia and Slovenia. The first written mention of Malvasia in Istria dates to a book from 1641 by a Novigrad bishop called Giacomo Tommasini, though the first detailed description of the grape is as late as 1891 when the grape was presented at a Zagreb exhibition. Red varieties dominated in Istria at that time, and it came to prominence only between the wars when a meeting in 1931 identified it as a priority for the region for producing premium and luxury wines. Its origin remains a mystery because it has no known parents, and no links to grapevines in Greece or Italy. The current best theory is that its homeland is Croatia, supported by a [2024 paper by Marinov *et al*](#) that showed ‘approximately three quarters of Continental/Istrian *sativa* ancestry and one quarter of Dalmatian *sativa* ancestry.’

| The Kozlović family, among those responsible for the revival of Malvazija Istarska in Croatia

Today, Malvazija Istarska is showing its quality potential and has become Croatia’s second most important grape even though confined to the Istrian peninsula (1,529 ha/3,778 acres by 2024). After a difficult socialist period as a volume workhorse, a handful of visionary producers rescued it in the 1990s (notably Kozlović and Matošević, who were also key figures in the founding of Vinistra in 1994). It has certainly made a home in Istria as a superstar variety and is proving both high quality and incredibly versatile, producing wines from sparkling to sweet, and particularly impressing in various dry guises. Around two-thirds is vinified in steel as fresh, fruity wines

typically consumed within a year of harvest, though even these 'simple' wines can defy expectations and age for a couple of decades. It also works well with judicious oak, skin-contact and as amphora wine (pioneered by Kabola), and its white-flower and honey aromas suit ageing in acacia (Matošević, Damjanić and Fakin do good versions). And recently, winemakers are moving beyond relying on winemaking for quality but showcasing single-vineyard and parcel selections (such as Kozlović Santa Lucia, Medea Montiron, Meneghetti's Moni Emvasis, Rossi Templara, Pilato Sur Lie).

Kabola winery in the north-west of the Istrian peninsula in Croatia, notable for amphora winemaking

The grape is also found in Slovenia, both in the Slovenian part of Istria where it produces typically mineral, saline versions and also it does well inland where it's usually just labelled Malvazija, without 'Istarska'. It arrived in the Brda hills when the area was part of the Venetian Republic when it was used to add aroma to blends with the more neutral Rebula. It survived socialism as it was planted in the lower, more frost-prone areas as it's more cold resistant.

It is now gaining popularity as a single variety as it does well where there's more clay – areas that don't suit the flagship Rebula. And it's usefully able to ripen in drought years because of the moisture in the clay. Alex Simčič (Edi Simčič, wines available via Bancroft in the UK) reckons it has more Mediterranean herbal notes – typically rosemary, thyme and white pepper – compared with the more fruity, floral coastal versions.

Croatia also has other Malvasias which take prominence on the label

and are unrelated to the Istrian one. Near Dubrovnik, Malvazija Dubrovačka (aka Malvasia di Bosa (Sardinia), Malvasia di Lipari (Sicily), Malvasia de Sitges (Catalunya)) has been rescued from near extinction even though it may be the oldest indigenous Croatian grape mentioned in writing – an archive document kept in Dubrovnik refers to Malvasia from 1383. It had almost disappeared and was down to just 250 vines in 2001, when a project to rescue it began, and it's now increased to 42 ha (104 acres) especially in Konavle near Dubrovnik.

Recent research by [Žeravica et al 2025](#) identified 54 volatile organic compounds – aroma and flavour contributors – that vary with both precise site location and vintage, a feature generally regarded as markers of a high-quality grape variety. It is usually vinified as a mineral, orange-scented dry wine, with occasional orange versions which can work remarkably well.

It's also being [revived in Sitges in Spain](#) in various styles including an iconic rancio, long-oak-aged version. Here it's gone from 2 to 128 ha (316 acres), in part thanks to the legacy of a lawyer and diplomat called Manuel Llopiš i de Casades (1885–1935) who bequeathed the remaining vineyards and the Sitges Malvasia cellar to Hospital Sant Joan Baptista, which has continued to make the wine. There are various stories about how it got to Spain – one tells of a light-infantry soldier who fought the Ottomans in Monemvasia in the 14th century and was cured of a war wound by Malvasia and possibly brought it home with him.

It also found a home in the Aeolian islands as Malvasia di Lipari where it makes delicious sweet wines from grapes sun-dried on straw mats or *cannizzi*, and even good orange wines.

Then there's another grape with a complex, travelling history around the region. The grape called Maraština or Rukatac in Croatia is at least five centuries old and has been found to be genetically identical

to Malvasia Bianca Lunga and Malvasia del Chianti. Plus, there are several black-skinned Malvasia grapes such as Malvasia Nera Casorzo, di Basilicata, di Brindisi, di Cilento and more. There’s even a wine competition every year organised by Vinistra in Croatia called World of Malvasia (declaration of interest – I am chair of judging) which aims to bring together as many versions of the grape from around the world as possible. Twelve countries have entered their wines up to 2025, including even surprising places such as Germany, Brazil, the US and Australia.

Some of the more important Malvasia varieties by planted area (2024)

Variety	Main synonyms	Main country (planted area)
Malvasia Istriana	Malvazija Istarska, Malvazija	Croatia (1,529 ha) Slovenia (987 ha)
Malvasia Dubrovačka	Malvazija Dubrovačka Malvasia de Lipari Malvasía de Sitges Malvasia de la Palma Malvasia di Bosa	Croatia (42 ha) Italy, Sicily (170 ha) Spain, Catalunya (128 ha) Spain, Canaries/Balearics (213 ha)
Malvasia	Maraština, Rukatac Malvasia del Chianti, Malvasia	Croatia (315 ha) Italy, Tuscany

Bianca Lunga	Toscana Pavlos	(1,247 ha) Greece*
Malvasia Bianca	Malvasia de la Rioja	Italy, Lazio (4,300 ha)
Malvasia Bianca di Candia	Malvasia Candida	Italy, Lazio (9,685 ha) USA (486 ha) Brazil (165 ha)
Malvasia Volcánica	Malvasia di Lanzarote	Canary Islands (786 ha)
Malvasia del Lazio	Malvasia Punctinata, Malvasia Gentile	Italy, Lazio (680 ha)
Malvasia Riojana	Alarije	Spain (4,905 ha)
Malvasia Fina	Boal	Portugal (3,282 ha)
Monemvasia- Malvasia		Greece (81 ha)

Malvasia
Nera di
Brindisi

Malvasia Nera di
Lecce
Malvasia Nera di
Bari

Italy (1,264 ha)

Information from Vinistra, VIVC.de, Slovenian official data, OIV, *planted area data not available.

The true Malvasia?

There's a separate story in trying to identify what is the true Malvasia and if there are indeed any family relationships. This was the subject of a [2025 paper by Fort *et al*](#) that analysed all the grapes linked to the name Malvasia and its variants. It looked at 43 grapevines with genetic profiles available, after removing synonyms, colour variants and commercial crosses, and varieties with no Malvasia profile by genetics or history (though this approach seems to have left out some significant Malvasia grapes with no genetic profile or offspring – such as Malvasia del Lazio). The team identified a population linked to northern Italy, and another linked to the southern Balkans and southern Italy.

They also argued that any Malvasia with Muscat parentage (many of the northern Italian ones, plus Argentina's Malvasia Criolla) should be considered to be in the Muscat family rather than Malvasia, and that there are also several grapes with Malvasia parentage but are not named Malvasia that should be considered part of the family.

They proposed that the true Malvasias are: (1) Malvasia Dubrovačka, Malvasia Bianca Lunga and Malvasia del Cilento, by genetic proximity; (2) Malvasia Volcánica, Malvasia Babosa, Malvasia Nera di Basilicata, Malvasia Nera di Brindisi, Vitovska, Pelena, Prunesta (false), and Lagorthi, via crosses; and (3) Malvasia di Sardegna Rosada, by mutation. Malvasia Istriana is considered to be distant

and by implication not part of this suggested family identity.

The story of Malvasia, its name and its origins, remains complicated, though clearly linked to a fascinating history of Mediterranean wine trading and changing wine fashions. And importantly there are many utterly delicious wines labelled Malvasia, so even if there is only a small family by genetics, there is clearly a wider family by adoption, and one well worth exploring.

Reviews of 35 impressive Malvasia wines tasted over the past year that express real typicality are presented below, grouped by region, as follows:

- [Istria](#)
- [Dalmatia](#)
- [Slovenia](#)
- [other regions](#)

Within those groups the wines are ordered alphabetically but you can change this.

Select sorting option ▼

Istria

Benvenuti, Livio Malvazija Istarska 2023 Hrvatska Istra

17.5 +/20

WHITE

Named for the late father of the two brothers that run the winery. Two plots of old vines: Turkovo planted in 1946 at 330 m of elevation and Motovun planted in 1962 at 170 m. Maceration and fermentation with ambient yeast for 15 days, aged in a 2,000-litre barrel for 12 months.

Inviting pear and stone-fruit aromas with notes of lemon zest and apple blossom. Silky and elegant to taste, with lemon-pith texture and stony salinity. Lingering. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Damjanić, Clemente 2022 Hrvatska Istra

17 +/20

WHITE

60% Malvazija Istarska, 30% Chardonnay, 10% Pinot Blanc from three plots on red soil. 12 months in oak barrels (225–300 litres) on the fine lees.

Ripe apple, white peach, poached pear with floral notes of meadowsweet and honeysuckle and a touch of vanilla. Plenty of fruit, layered complexity and a subtle touch of toasted hazelnut. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Deklić, Konstantin Malvazija Istarska 2021 Hrvatska Istra

17.5 +/20

WHITE

Named after the winemaker's grandfather Konstantin, born in 1939 and still working in the vineyards. The best grapes from deep red soil near Vižinada. 5-day cold maceration, then fermented and aged on the lees in oak.

Fine nose with creamy white peach and touches of tangerine zest and wild thyme. It's silky in texture, with gentle acidity, appetising, zippy salinity and harmonious oak in the background. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Fakin Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

From white soils in the Motovun area. 3 hours' maceration in the press.

Whistle-clean, inviting nose with green apple, honeydew melon and a twist of green herbs and acacia flower. Charming, fresh and drinkable. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Fakin, La Prima Malvazija Istarska 2023 Hrvatska Istra

18.5/20

WHITE

From a micro-plot planted 1952 and 1954 – one of the oldest Malvazija vineyards still in commercial use. Four days' maceration then fermented and aged for 12 months in 2,000-litre Croatian acacia barrels.

Rich, golden yellow – almost amber wine. Golden plum, chestnut honey, ground coriander and quince aromas. Intense but sleek and beautifully harmonious, with lemon zest, mirabelle and a touch of beeswax backed by vibrant acidity. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Price: \$62 Croatian Premium Wine

Kabola, Unica Malvazija Istarska 2021 Hrvatska Istra

17.5 +/20

WHITE

Spontaneous fermentation for 7–10 days with skins in 4,000-litre oak. Pressed and returned to the same oak for 12 months' ageing.

Light gold, with toasted almond, quince and a touch of coriander and dried fig on the nose. Weighty and textured, with juicy peach, stone fruit, a hint of butterscotch, fine-grained tannins and real vibrancy. (CG)

Drink: 2026 – 2030

Kabola, Amfora Malvazija Istarska 2020 Hrvatska Istra

17.5/20

WHITE

Kabola is the pioneer of amphora wines in Istria. 6 months on skins, 12 months large neutral oak. Certified organic.

Bright amber wine, with sandalwood, fresh herbs, golden plum and quince *membrillo* on the nose. This has a lovely, complex texture – rounded and sleek with a touch of saltiness, along with hints of

tropical fruit and just a touch of citrus-pith grip to provide structure and longevity. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2032

Price: £28.99 Novel Wines

Kadum Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

A young producer to watch, they released their first wines in 2019.

Three kilometres from the sea on deep red soils.

Super-precise winemaking here, showing hawthorn blossom, acacia and fresh pear aromas. An appetising, zesty, crisp wine with a nicely juicy mid palate and a lightly saline finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Kozlović Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

16.5/20

WHITE

Vines aged between 18 and 83 years. From 3 plots – Valle, Santa Lucia and Contarini.

A benchmark for fresh Malvazija Istarska varietal expression. Ripe apple, lemon and apple-blossom aromas. Good intensity, with flavours of juicy pear and lemon zest and a hint of salinity. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Imported into the UK by Hallgarten & Novum Wines

Kozlović, Santa Lucia Malvazija Istarska 2018 Hrvatska Istra

18.5 +/20

WHITE

Pioneering family winery. Single-vineyard selection from vines planted in 1961, 7 km from the sea. Cryo-maceration for 5–6 days. Fermented and aged for 6 months in 3,000-litre oak. Certified organic.

Lovely, inviting, layered meadowsweet, acacia honey and poached medlar aromas, with a hint of chamomile and mock orange. Rounded and supple to taste, with chestnut honey, quince and dried pear.

Super intensity, steely vibrancy and a lingering, saline texture. (CG)
Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2033

Medea, Montiron Malvazija Istarska 2023 Hrvatska Istra

17.5/20

WHITE

A parcel selection from a 43-year-old vineyard planted before clonal selection. 24 hours' cold soak, part-fermented in oak, four months on lees.

Bright lemon yellow. Ripe white peach, greengage and golden melon with a light touch of lemon flowers. Whistle-clean, with sleek, supple texture backed by nice vibrancy and good length, and well-handled oak that adds another dimension. (CG)

Drink: 2026 – 2029

Matošević, Alba Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

From estate-owned vineyards.

A classic, fresh example of the grape, with fine aromas of chamomile, apple blossom, peach and green pear. To taste, it's fine, linear and appetising, with touches of melon, zesty lemon and green almond. (CG)

Alcohol: 12.5% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Price: £18.95 VINVM

Matošević, Alba Antiqua Malvazija Istarska 2021 Hrvatska Istra

17.5+/20

WHITE

From 250–300 m of elevation. 48 hours' maceration, fermented and

aged in acacia barrels for 12 months.

Super-complex nose with hints of lemongrass, poached pear, mirabelle and beeswax. Generously fruity with touches of pineapple and lemon, with a sleek, elegant structure and a little lime pith on the finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Imported into the UK by Liberty Wines

Matošević, Grimalda 2022 Hrvatska Istra

17.5/20

WHITE

A blend of 45% Malvazija Istarska, 45% Chardonnay and 10% Sauvignon Blanc. From an isolated plot planted in 2003. Aged in oak for 12 months on the lees. Certified organic.

A bouquet of fresh summer hay, lemon zest, stone fruit and ripe apple. Nicely textured with a juicy core, great harmony and a notably saline finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Pilato Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

Picked mid August. Fermented in stainless steel, no maceration. Certified organic.

A grassy, fresh, lemony and vibrant expression of Malvazija Istarska. Linear and crisp, light and appetising, with notes of lemon balm, green apple and fennel. (CG)

Alcohol: 12% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Pilato, Sur Lie Malvazija Istarska 2020 Hrvatska Istra

18 +/20

WHITE

From a red-soil vineyard. 12 hours' maceration, fermentation started in steel, finished in barrel. Four months' ageing in oak.

Hugely appealing bouquet with fine apple-blossom and fresh-cut-pear aromas. A gorgeous expression of Malvazija Istarska with intensity, elegance, subtle oak creaminess and a fine lemon-zest and mineral backbone. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2024 – 2030

Price: £29.99 Novel Wines

Rossi, Templara Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

18/20

WHITE

Run by three brothers, the fifth generation of a family winery going back to 1885. From old vines in the family's 'grand cru' Monte d'Oro vineyard on white soil. Ten months in large 1,000-litre and 2,000-litre French oak.

Full-bodied, supple and sleek, with ripe apple, plum and toasted hazelnut and well-integrated vanilla nuances, supported by gentle acidity and a long finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Tomaz, Sesto Senso Malvazija Istarska 2021 Hrvatska Istra

17.5/20

WHITE

21 days' maceration. Aged in mulberry, acacia and oak barrels for 18 months.

An amber-gold wine, with spicy honeysuckle and blood-orange-zest aromas. Ripe peach fruit with wild-herb complexity, hints of cinnamon and a lively, salty finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Veralda, Xtriana Malvazija Istarska 2023 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

Aged for five months on the lees in stainless-steel tanks. Certified organic.

Inviting golden wine with aromas of fresh meadow hay, lemon zest and a touch of acacia blossom. To taste, it's zesty with juicy peach fruit, mineral notes, good acidity and great precision. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Veralda, Castagnari Malvazija Istarska 2021 Hrvatska Istra

17.5/20

WHITE

A selection from a single vineyard on white soil. 6-hour maceration. Fermented in stainless-steel with a pied de cuve. Aged in the same vessels on the lees for 2 years. Certified organic.

Fine, expressive nose – greengage, melon and lime zest with overtones of mint and meadowsweet. It's ripe and generous on the palate, with mirabelle, honeydew melon and a fresh, lightly saline, long finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 14.5% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Vina Laguna, Festigia Malvazija Istarska 2024 Hrvatska Istra

17/20

WHITE

Selected fruit from two plots on red soil near the coast and white soil at Vižinada. 6–12 hours' maceration, 3 months on lees.

Light lemon-yellow, showing notes of lemon curd, jasmine and a touch of sweet spice. To taste, hints of white peach and pineapple juice are backed by meadow herbs, citrus zest and an appetising touch of pithy bitterness. Benchmark varietal expression from Istria's biggest producer. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Dalmatia

Baraka, Tenebra Maraština 2022 Sjeverna Dalmacija

17/20

WHITE

From the Šibenik region. A single-vineyard wine. 24 hours'

maceration. Spontaneous fermentation, 70% in concrete eggs, 30% in 225-litre French oak barrels. The producer tries to bottle at the time of the full moon (the wine's name means 'eclipse').

A rather inviting, peachy nose overlaid with sweet spice. The sleek, rounded palate shows papaya, mango and tangerine notes, with a supple, creamy hint of oak. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2025 – 2029

Bora Maraština 2024 Sjeverna Dalmacija

17 +/20

WHITE

A small 7-ha winery run by a father and son, established in 2015. Peaches, greengage and mock orange on the nose. It's super-clean, with fine white peach and a touch of bitter orange pith. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Crvik, Blasius Orange Malvasija Dubrovačka 2022 Srednja i Južna Dalmacija

17 +/20

WHITE

From the Konvale region. Spontaneously fermented on the skins for 9 months in 500-litre oak, 75% new Slavonian medium-toast barrels. Complex peach and papaya fruit with orange-blossom aromas. Surprisingly fruity with poached nectarine, cinnamon and orange zest. Saline, with a firm but mellow backbone. Very clean and a really drinkable style. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2030

Ante Sladić Maraština 2023 Dalmatinska Zagora

17.5 +/20

WHITE

Family winery in Skradin, near Krka national park. Organic farming. 24-hour maceration. Fermented and aged on the lees, 30% in oak, 70% in stainless-steel.

Aromas of orange, melon and white peach. Good texture and intensity, with attractive acid lift. An effortlessly delicious wine. (CG)
Drink: 2026 – 2028

Volarević, 25 Perpera Malvasija Dubrovačka 2024 Srednja i Južna Dalmacija

17/20

WHITE

From the Komarna region. Named for a coin from the Dubrovnik Republic. 24 hours' maceration.

Mid-golden wine. Thyme, chamomile and lemon-curd aromas lead onto juicy, saline yellow-plum flavours, with a touch of lime leaf and green almond on the finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Volarević, Kremena Malvasija Dubrovačka 2023 Srednja i Južna Dalmacija

17 +/20

WHITE

From the Komarna region. 19 days' maceration in used oak.

Mid-golden wine with sweet spice, white peach, dried-pear aromas and a hint of tangerine oil. To taste, it has a creamy texture, with golden plum, poached pear, and a bitter-orange, wet-stone finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 12.5% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Price: \$69 (2020) Croatian Premium Wine

Zoro Malvasija Dubrovačka 2024 Srednja i Južna Dalmacija

16.5/20

WHITE

From a micro plot within the Konavle region, with very cold nights, just a couple of miles south of Dubrovnik airport. A few hours' maceration. Fermented in stainless steel.

Inviting green-herb and melon aromas – almost grassy. It's clean,

lively and fresh, with crunchy apple, lime and mineral hints. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Slovenia

Ferdinand, Época Malvazija 2022 Goriška Brda

17 + /20

WHITE

A single-vineyard selection. A few hours' cold maceration, fermented and aged on the fine lees for 12 months in 500-litre oak barrels.

A glowing golden-yellow wine with aromas of meadow herbs, fennel and lemon oil. To taste, there's ample, ripe, juicy plum and nectarine, with subtle, creamy oak and a zesty, vibrant finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Gašper Malvazija 2024 Goriška Brda

16.5 + /20

WHITE

Personal label of wine merchant and former Slovenian champion sommelier Gašper Carman, produced at Klet Brda.

Whistle-clean aromas of melon, green papaya and fresh herbs, with hints of hawthorn blossom. It's crisp, zippy, saline and refreshing to taste, with Asian pear, crunchy apple, lime cordial and a vibrant, mineral finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13.5% Drink: 2025 – 2027

Imported into the UK by Liberty Wines

Edi Simčič Malvazija 2023 Goriška Brda

17.5 /20

WHITE

Fermented and aged in mostly used barrels for 9–10 months.

Mid gold. Ripe yellow plum intertwined with fresh hay and wild-thyme notes, and a touch of creamy oak. Sleek, harmonious palate. Juicy pineapple and mirabelle, golden melon and a touch of

elderflower, with saline citrus-pith undertones. (CG)
Alcohol: 14% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Price: £24.70 VINVM

Other regions

Colosi, Na'jm Passito 2022 Malvasia delle Lipari

17.5 +/20

WHITE

95% Malvasia delle Lipari, 5% Corinto Nero. Sun-dried grapes fermented and aged in stainless-steel tanks. RS 157 g/l.

Just delicious. Juicy peach and mango, honey, sultana and a floral hint. Exquisitely balanced acidity and a lingering finish. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Price: £19.90 per 50 cl Svinando

El Grifo, Lías Malvasía Volcánica 2022 Lanzarote

16.5 +/20

WHITE

An inviting and delicate nose of fresh apricot, with a light scent of lemon blossom. To taste, this is whistle-clean, pure and juicy, with hints of Asian pear fruit, creamy lees complexity and a saline mineral backbone. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Price: £26.95 Vinissimus

Idaia, Malva de Crete 2024 PGI Crete

17 -/20

WHITE

Malvasia di Candia. Dry-farmed in Malevizio province, south of Heraklion, at 400–500 m. Cool fermentation in stainless-steel tanks with selected yeasts.

Fragrant, pretty, jasmine-scented nose. Clean, appetising and crisp, with bright orchard fruit – nice precision. (CG)

Alcohol: 13% Drink: 2026 – 2028

Vukoje, Terroir Premium Malvasija Dubrovačka 2020 Hercegovina

17 + / 20

WHITE

From the Zazad vineyard. Three weeks' maceration, two years' ageing in oak.

Very rich orange-amber. Bright peach and mango on the nose, with overtones of sage and rosemary. Generously fruity with notes of ripe peach and poached apricot, toasted nuts, orange marmalade and chestnut honey, backed by some sapid grip and very good acidity.
(CG)

Alcohol: 12.5% Drink: 2026 – 2029

Price: £35 NIKO

For some Malvasia wines to try, see [more than 250 reviews](#) in our tasting notes database.

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